

FROM SCIENTIFIC OPPORTUNITY TO SCIENTIFIC PUBLIC GOOD

An Operating Lens for Public Data for Health

THE OPPORTUNITY

OpenAI Foundation's Public Data for Health initiative is supporting the creation and preservation of high-quality scientific datasets, with initial hypotheses centered on Connected, Scarce, and Direct data.¹ Identifying valuable data, however, is only the beginning. Scientific opportunities must still move through institutions, collaborators, governance requirements, technical dependencies, and the practical realities of creating or preserving resources that other researchers can actually use.

OPERATING QUESTION

Once a scientifically valuable data opportunity has been identified, what operating conditions help translate philanthropic capital into a responsibly accessible, usable, and durable scientific public good?

THE OPERATING LENS



Learn and refine throughout. Validate scientific and public value; pressure-test dependencies; activate people, partnerships, capital, and decision rights; execute while distinguishing scientific uncertainty from execution risk; enable use beyond the original team; and sustain the resource beyond initial funding.

THE INSTITUTIONAL LAST MILE

Scientific programs do not execute in the abstract; they execute through institutions. A funding decision may establish scientific intent and provide resources, but activation can still depend on data rights, participant protections, institutional requirements, partner agreements, technical capacity, staffing, infrastructure, and decision authority.

Pressure-test: What is the actual bottleneck? → Who owns the decision? → When must it be resolved? → What work can responsibly proceed in parallel?

An unresolved dependency should trigger investigation before rejection. Some uncertainties can remain open while work proceeds; others must be resolved before a particular activity or commitment becomes responsible.

**The objective is neither maximum speed nor maximum control.
It is appropriate sequencing.**

Capital commitments can remain responsive to evidence. Where appropriate, the scale and reversibility of a commitment can reflect the evidence available and the maturity of decision-relevant dependencies. The point is not to impose a single funding structure, but to preserve the ability to adapt as execution reveals what the next decision requires.

FROM DATASET TO SCIENTIFIC PUBLIC GOOD

For shared scientific infrastructure, release is an important milestone, not the endpoint. A resource can technically be public yet remain difficult to discover, understand, appropriately access, use, or sustain.



Accessible includes the ability to discover, understand, and appropriately access the resource. The appropriate access mechanism may differ based on the nature of the data, applicable rights and participant protections, and intended scientific use.

A scientifically valuable dataset becomes a scientific public good when researchers beyond the original project can responsibly access, understand, use, and build upon it - allowing the value of the original investment to compound across the scientific community.

MEASURE THE PATH TO VALUE

EXECUTION HEALTH	RESOURCE HEALTH	SCIENTIFIC UTILITY & LEARNING
Are milestones advancing, dependencies resolving, and partners delivering?	Is the intended resource being created or preserved, appropriately accessible, documented, and positioned for stewardship?	Are researchers beyond the original project using the resource? What are they learning, and what does that evidence imply?

Delivery, utility, scientific learning, and longer-term benefit are related but distinct signals along the path to value. As outcomes move further downstream, attribution to any single investment generally becomes more difficult.

ONE LENS. DIFFERENT BOTTLENECKS.

CTD COMMONS SCARCE	UNC GENERATIVE IMMUNOTHERAPY DIRECT	OPENADMET CONNECTED
Knowledge at risk of disappearing creates urgency. Implication: urgency can change sequencing without eliminating responsible governance. ¹	A multimodal resource involving human biological and clinical information makes eventual responsible use part of the design problem. Implication: design for downstream use early enough that access and stewardship are not end-of-project surprises. ¹	Value depends on connecting measurements across contributors, not merely collecting individual deliverables. Implication: individual partner success does not necessarily equal system success. ¹

FROM PROJECTS TO PORTFOLIO LEARNING

Evidence from individual projects can strengthen judgment across the portfolio and inform subsequent investments. The objective is not to standardize ambitious science. It is to create enough operating structure to move quickly where urgency matters, resolve dependencies when they become decision-relevant, preserve room for scientific uncertainty, and adapt as evidence develops. Done well, philanthropic capital creates scientific resources whose value can compound across the research community - while each investment strengthens the ability to make the next one.

Source
1. OpenAI Foundation, Public Data for Health, Sept. 15, 2026. Foundation descriptions of the program, Connected/Scarce/Direct hypotheses, and OpenADMET, CTD Commons, and UNC Initiative for Generative Immunotherapy. Analysis and operating implications in this memo are the author's. Developed from publicly available information as an illustrative operating perspective. It does not presume OpenAI Foundation's internal processes or program design.